

MEDIA ANALYSIS



Ethics of Accountability: Athletes and Family Behavior in the Media

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INTRODUCTION

From the beginning, family are heavily involved in their athlete child's life, some in a good way, some in a bad.

At the professional level, the exposure of athlete's families aren't as prevalent, with the exception of some. There are instances of families being shown in the media when someone makes their debut, a milestone is reached, something personal, etc.

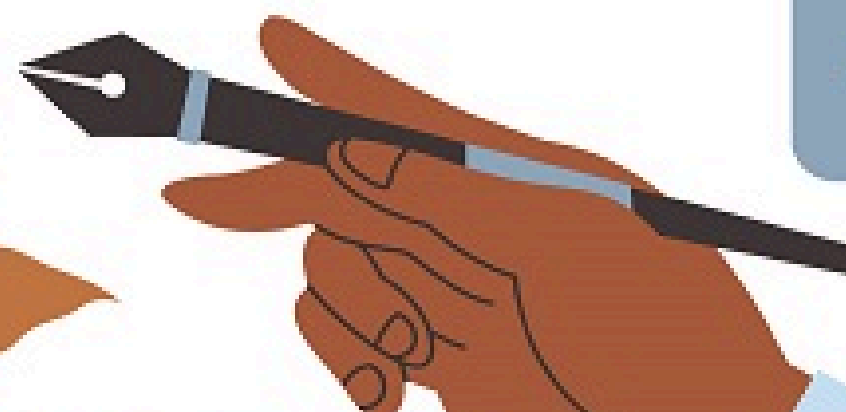
There are also instances of family members acting out, being outspoken and a nuisance. **Should those athletes be held responsible for their family member's actions and expected to speak out?**



PRESS

NEWS

WORLD



PRESS



PAT MAHOMES AND HIS KID BROTHER

In 2021, Pat Mahomes younger brother, Jackson, was caught on video pouring water on Ravens fans after a Kansas City Chiefs loss. His defense, *“they were thirsty.”* Pat responded by saying, *“Obviously, it’s something we don’t want to necessarily do. He’ll learn from it.”*

The same year, he got heat for dancing on Sean Taylor’s number on the day of its retirement for the Washington Football Team for a Tik Tok video. While Jackson apologized, Pat acknowledged that his brother takes a lot and will learn from it and stay away from those people.



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Yup..fire the questioner



#EGE @smithunleashed
Replying to @_MLFootball and @nypost
whoever asked that should be fired

11:03 AM · May 25, 2023



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Following these actions, Jackson was accused of sexual misconduct in 2023

After being questioned at a press conference about the incident, Pat responded by saying he’d like to keep it to himself and that it’s a *“personal matter.”* Fans called for the firing of the reporter that asked about that incident.

BIG BALLER BRAND

Lavar's 'white guys' Comment

Lavar Ball, father of Lonzo and LaMelo, sparked controversy from the beginning during his UCLA days with his outspokenness.

When UCLA lost to Kentucky in the 2017 NCAA tournament, Lavar was quoted saying, *“realistically, you can’t win no championship with three white guys because the foot speed is too slow.”*

Lonzo downplayed his dad’s comments by saying, *“He probably said it was a joke. The media is going to do what they do with it, and I’ve heard him say it before so it’s nothing new for me.”*

LiAngelo Ball followed it up with commenting that it is all good because he and his brothers are half-white.

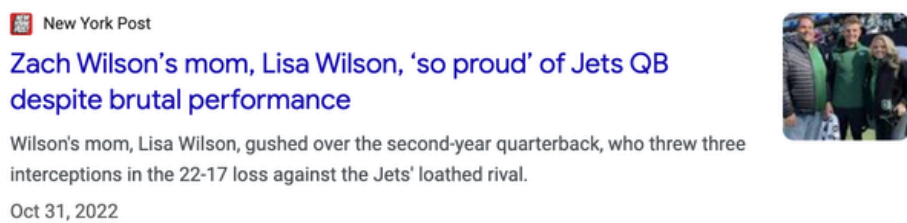
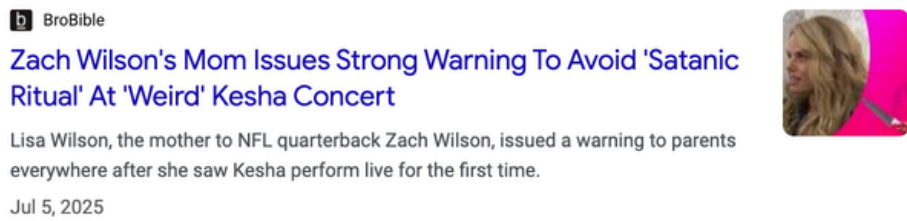
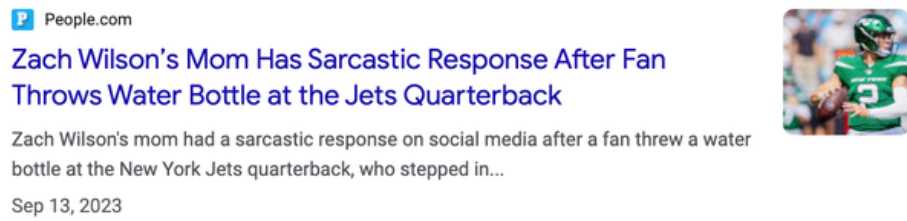
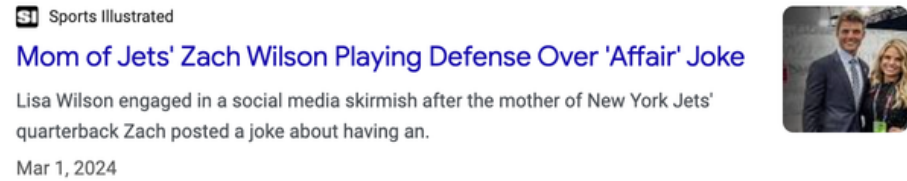
“He always talks”

In 2018, while Lonzo was on the Lakers, Lavar stated that Lonzo wouldn’t re-sign unless the Lakers also signed LiAngelo.

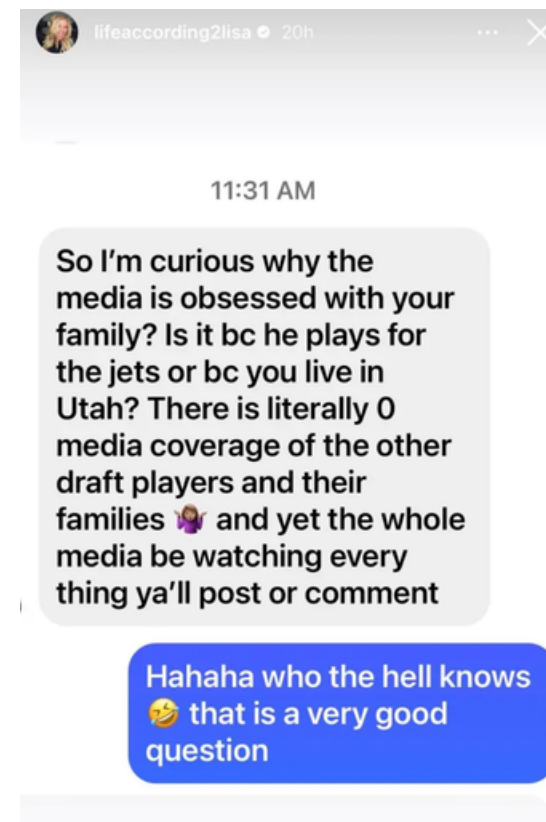
Shorly after, Lonzo told the media that he had no reaction to those statements, claiming, *“I always just play. He always talks. It’s always been the same way.”*



ZACH WILSON'S MOTHER



- In 2022, a rumor spread that Zach Wilson had an inappropriate relationship with his mother's friend
- She faces harassment from NFL fans due to her behavior on social media
- Articles refer to her as “Zach Wilson’s mother” connecting his name to her negative media presence



- Very vocal on social media
- Publicly argues with haters
- Monetizes her “influencer” role
 - Sponsorships
 - Blog type posts

COMPETING SIDES



Athletes should be held responsible:

- Modern athletes are public figures
- Speaking out shows accountability
- Families enjoy the perks and fame of the athlete
 - They should share ethical responsibility for public behavior

Athletes should NOT be held responsible:

- Athletes are individuals
- They cannot control the actions of others
- Journalists should separate professional performance from personal drama
- Demanding a public reaction violates privacy

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS?

- Should journalists include family controversies in coverage of athletes?
- At what point does a family member's behavior become newsworthy?
- Is public accountability fair when fame extends to family?
- Would you handle this differently as a PR rep or a journalist?



MEDIA STANCES

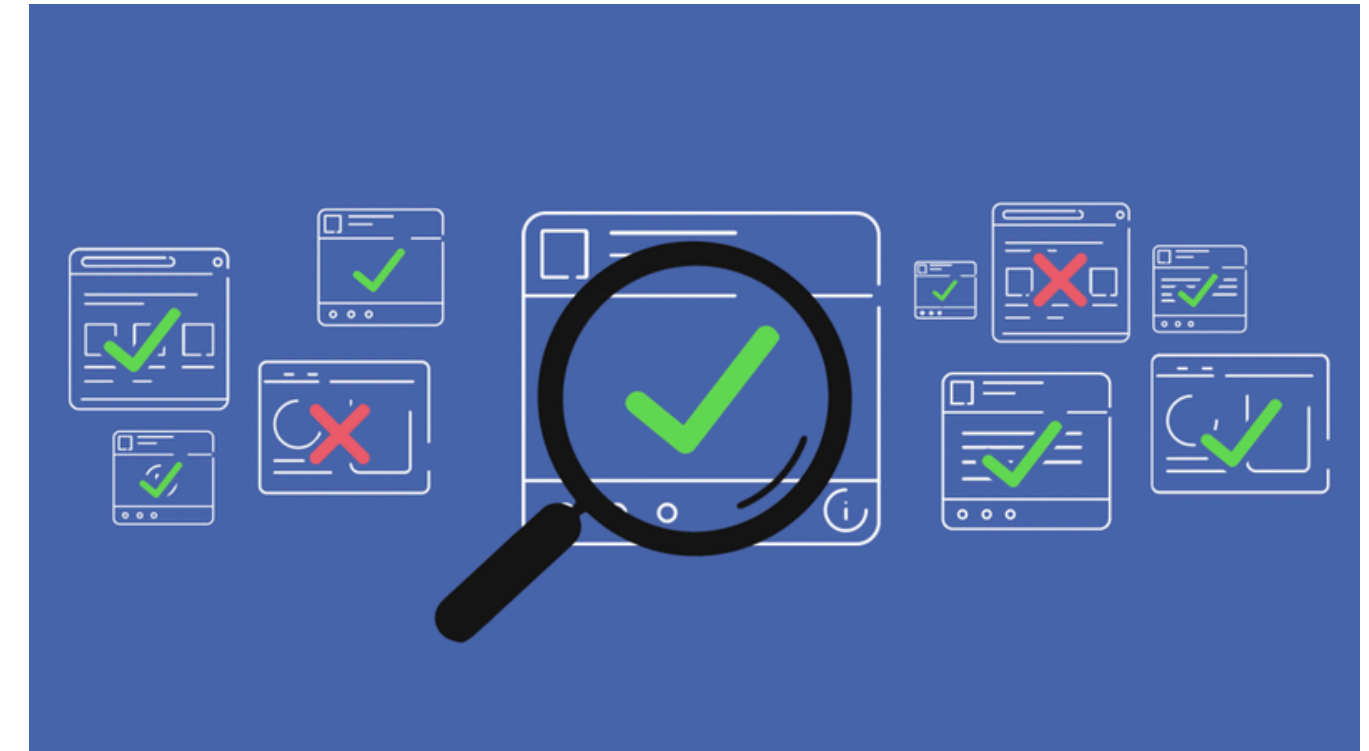
- Some media outlets including a podcast on *Cleveland* expresses how journalists play a significant role in shaping narratives, sometimes crossing the line from reporting into commentary on personal lives.
- Athletes have even created their own platforms like PlayersTV that shares content towards the humanization of athletes and focuses on them and their families lives positively beyond the sport
- During the Paris Olympics, NBC published heartfelt images of athletes and their children to challenge the status quo of overly invasive journaling



ETHICAL GUIDELINES

Seek Truth and Report It:

- Report *facts* about the athlete only when relevant; avoid implying guilt by association
 - Sports journalists are often advised to avoid quoting family members
- Athletes and their families are entitled to private lives and reporting is often considered a breach of journalistic ethics



Minimize Harm:

- Don't exploit family tragedy or embarrassment just for clicks or headlines
- SPJ Code of Ethics addresses these issues, emphasizing the importance of minimizing harm & showing compassion towards those who may be affected

THE “UNETHICAL” POSITION

The rise of social media and the blurring lines between public and private life make this a constant tightrope walk

- As The Times Delphic reported, “the landscape has changed, and journalists can no longer blindly accept narratives about an athlete’s personal life without skepticism.”



DISCUSSION QUESTIONS?

- Where should the media draw the line between fair coverage and invasion of privacy?
- Should fame automatically extend to an athlete's family – or should they be treated as private citizens?



- If a family member's actions hurt an athlete's brand, should PR teams or journalists address it publicly?
- How can journalists report on these controversies without causing unnecessary harm

OUR POSITION AND RATIONALE



We believe athletes should not be held responsible for their family members' actions.

Rationale:

- Athletes cannot control others' behavior.
- Holding them accountable blurs personal and professional boundaries.
- Journalists have an ethical duty to avoid guilt by association and to report only what's relevant to performance or public conduct.
- This protects fairness, accuracy, and privacy while still allowing legitimate reporting on public matters.



TAKEAWAY

Accountability and privacy can coexist, but only when journalists focus on the athlete's professional conduct and respect family boundaries.



CITATIONS



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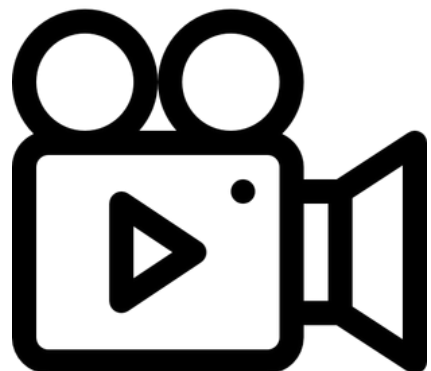
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THANK YOU

